

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

-----X
RICHARD BRUCE,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, SHEIKH AKTARUZZAMAN,
and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10,

Defendants.
-----X

SUMMONS

Index No.

Plaintiff Designates Bronx County as
the Proper Venue for Trial

Venue is the County where the Cause
of Action Arose

TO THE ABOVE-NAMED DEFENDANTS:

YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED to answer the complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance, on the Plaintiff's Attorneys within 20 days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service (or within 30 days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York); and in case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

Dated: Bayside, New York
April 17, 2023

By: 
SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP
By: Sameer Nath, Esq.
Attorneys for Plaintiff
42-40 Bell Boulevard – Suite 405
Bayside, New York 11361
(718) 281-0400

TO: **CITY OF NEW YORK**

Via Corporation Counsel of The City Of New York

100 Church Street

New York, New York 10007

SHEIKH AKTARUZZAMAN

Shield No. 26939, Tax Registry No. 966929

Via NYPD 42nd Precinct

830 Washington Avenue

Bronx, New York 10451

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

-----X
RICHARD BRUCE,

Plaintiff,

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Index No.

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, SHEIKH AKTARUZZAMAN,
and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10,

Defendants.

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Plaintiff, RICHARD BRUCE, individually, by and through the undersigned attorneys, Sim & DePaola, LLP, for his complaint against Defendants, **CITY OF NEW YORK, SHEIKH AKTARUZZAMAN**, and **JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10**, alleges and states as follows:

1. This is a civil rights action, in which Plaintiff seeks relief and redress against defendants, vis-à-vis sections 1981, 1983, 1985, 1986 and 1988 of Title 42 to the Code of Laws of the United States, for the violations of his civil rights under the First, Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States, the constitution of the State of New York, in addition to the laws of the City and State of New York.
2. The following claims arose on August 17, 2020 in the vicinity of the intersection of East 169th Street and Fox Street, Bronx, New York, when defendants, acting under color of state law, unlawfully stopped, searched and seized, battered and assaulted, detained, arrested and prosecuted Plaintiff without probable cause, reasonable suspicion, valid search or arrest warrant, or any other legal justification whatsoever to do so.
3. As a result, Plaintiff was caused to be unlawfully detained over the course of two (2) days until his eventual release from the physical custody of defendants on or about August 18, 2020.

4. Plaintiff **RICHARD BRUCE** was maliciously prosecuted and denied his rights to Fair Trial and Due Process from the date of his arraignment, until all adverse charges under Bronx Arrest No. B20621273 were summarily and unconditionally dismissed and sealed, pursuant to sections 160.50 or 160.60 of the New York Criminal Procedure Law on or about June 15, 2021.

5. At all times here mentioned, defendants were acting under color of state law, to wit, under color of the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies, customs and usages of the City and State of New York.

6. Within ninety (90) days of the accrual dates of the state law claims herein, Plaintiff served the New York City Comptroller's Office with written notice of said claims.

7. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since the service of said notice, and this matter has not been settled or otherwise disposed of.

8. Plaintiff has complied with the municipal Defendant's demand for an oral examination, pursuant to section 50-h of the General Municipal Law or no such demand has been noticed within the time permitted by law.

9. State law claims herein have been commenced within three years of the dates from which they arose, in addition to applicable infancy, tolling limitations pursuant to CPLR §208.

10. The above-referenced acts caused Plaintiff to be deprived of his liberty, his right to be from unreasonable searches and seizures, in addition to his rights to be afforded a Fair Trial, Due Process and the Equal Protection of the Law.

11. Plaintiff seeks monetary damages (compensatory and punitive) against Defendants, an award of costs and attorney's fees, with all interest then accrued, in addition to such other or further relief, as this Court may deem just and proper.

PARTIES

12. Plaintiff, Mr. RICHARD BRUCE (“Plaintiff”), is a Black or African American, male, who resides in Bronx, New York.

13. Defendant, CITY OF NEW YORK (“CITY”), is a municipal corporation duly organized and existing under the laws of the State of New York.

14. At all relevant times herein, the New York City Police Department (“NYPD”) is a wholly owned subsidiary which is further fully operated, managed, maintained, and controlled by Defendant City.

15. At all relevant times herein, Defendant CITY, acting through its NYPD, was responsible for the policy, practice, supervision, implementation, and conduct of all NYPD matters and was responsible for the appointment, training, supervision, discipline and retention and conduct of all NYPD personnel, including police officers, detectives, and supervisory officers, including the individually named Defendants herein.

16. At all relevant times herein, Defendant CITY was responsible for enforcing the rules of the NYPD, and for ensuring that the NYPD personnel, including the individually named defendants herein, obey the laws of the United States, as well as the City and State of New York.

17. At all relevant times herein, Defendant, SHEIKH AKTARUZZAMAN (“AKTARUZZAMAN”) was a police officer, supervisor, police maker, or official under NYPD Tax Id No. 966929 and Shield No. 26939, and, as such, was acting as an agent, servant, or employee of the City of New York. Defendant AKTARUZZAMAN is currently assigned to the 42nd Precinct of the NYPD. Defendant AKTARUZZAMAN is being sued in his individual and official capacity.

18. At all relevant times, Defendants, JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, were police officers, detectives, supervisors, policymakers or officials employed by the NYPD. At this time, Plaintiff s are not privy to the true identities of defendants, JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, as such knowledge is within the exclusive possession of defendants.

19. At all relevant times herein, Defendants, JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, were acting as agents, servants and employees of the City of New York or the NYPD. Defendants, JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

20. At all relevant times herein, Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, were acting under color of state law, to wit, under color of the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies, customs and usages of the City and State of New York.

FACTUAL CHARGES

21. On August 17, 2020, at approximately 8:00 p.m., Plaintiff was illegally stopped, seized and searched, battered and assaulted, detained, and arrested by or at the direction of Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, in the vicinity of the intersection of East 169th Street and Fox Street, Bronx, New York.

22. On said date and time, Plaintiff was lawfully walking in obedience of all laws, ordinances, and statutes when Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10 approached, tackled, wrestled, and slammed Plaintiff to the ground in an excessive and illegal fashion. Said Defendants slammed Plaintiff into a steel gate or fence. Defendants struck Plaintiff with asp expandable batons or impact weapons. At no point did Plaintiff physically resist Defendants nor did Plaintiff present a physical threat or menace to them or anyone else.

23. Afterwards, Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, then illegally seized Plaintiff's person by grabbing him with their outstretched arms, accused him

of criminal offense, and violently contorted his arms behind his back to affix metal handcuffs to Plaintiff's wrists in an excessively tightened fashion, causing Plaintiff to experience substantial pain, shock, and extreme emotional distress.

24. While Plaintiff was being handcuffed and not resisting in any way, Defendants including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10 forcefully, violently and excessively wrenched Plaintiff's arm behind his back causing further injury.

25. Plaintiff complained to defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, that the handcuffs were too tight, causing Plaintiff to suffer substantial pain but said defendants either ignored or outright refused Plaintiff's requests to loosen the handcuffs.

26. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, then proceeded to conduct an illegal search of Plaintiff's person, without probable cause, reasonable suspicion, valid search or arrest warrant, or any legal justification whatsoever.

27. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, then placed Plaintiff in a police vehicle and transported him against his will to the 42nd Precinct, where Plaintiff was fingerprinted, searched, photographed, questioned as to his pedigree, unlawfully interrogated without presence of counsel, and illegally detained in a dank and dirty cell whereupon Plaintiff was transported to Central Booking where Plaintiff was fingerprinted, searched, photographed, retina-scanned, and illegally detained throughout various cells before being released from physical custody. Plaintiff was illegally detained over the course of approximately two (2) days.

28. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, lacked any probable cause or reasonable suspicion to stop, seize or arrest Plaintiff, because defendants never observed Plaintiff commit any crime or violation of the law and were never informed that Plaintiff committed any crime or violation of the law.

29. Due to the lack of probable cause for the searches or seizures of Plaintiff's person or property, the aforementioned conduct constituted the completed torts of assault and battery by defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10.

30. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, caused Plaintiff to suffer myriad of psychological and physical injuries believed to be permanent.

31. Prior to Plaintiff being arraigned in criminal court, Defendant AKTARUZZAMAN caused a criminal court complaint to be filed against Plaintiff in Bronx County Criminal Court, which falsely accused Plaintiff of committing criminal acts.

32. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, knowingly, maliciously and intentionally engaged in the fabrication of false and fictitious evidence, observations, events and occurrences, which defendants falsely attributed to Plaintiff before forwarding to prosecutors of the Bronx County District Attorney's Office.

33. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, engaged in fraud, the suppression of evidence, perjury, the gross deviation from acceptable police conduct and other conduct undertaken in bad faith, including the withholding of other video surveillance recordings, witness statements or accounts, an abject lack of inculpatory evidence, and other governmental issued forms, which all directly contradict the false allegations against him by defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10.

34. Plaintiff asserts that defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, falsely arrested, wrongfully detained and maliciously prosecuted Plaintiff with the full knowledge that he had committed no crime or violation of the law.

35. Plaintiff, therefore asserts that due to the clear absence of any viable probable cause to warrant the initiation or continuation of his criminal prosecution, at any point, he was maliciously

prosecuted and denied his rights to Fair Trial and Due Process by defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, who never possessed probable cause to believe that Plaintiff was guilty of any crime or offense, or that the prosecution would succeed.

36. As a result, Plaintiff was caused to be unlawfully, involuntarily and continuously detained by defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10 over the course of approximately three (3) days until his release eventual from physical custody on, or about, March 15, 2021.

37. Plaintiff was maliciously prosecuted and denied his rights to Fair Trial and Due Process from the date of his arraignment, until the underlying criminal court proceedings were terminated in favor of Plaintiff when all adverse charges under Bronx County Criminal Court Docket No. CR-004003-21BX were summarily and unconditionally dismissed and sealed, upon consideration of the merits thereof, pursuant to §§160.50 or 160.60 of the New York Criminal Procedure Law which constituted s termination of the criminal proceedings in favor of the accused.

38. At all times relevant hereto, the defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, involved in the decision to stop, seize, arrest and prosecute Plaintiff without reasonable suspicion or probable cause, or failed to intervene when they observed others doing so in the absence of any reasonable suspicion or probable cause.

39. At all times relevant hereto, the defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, subjected Plaintiff to excessive force, or failed to intervene when they observed others subjecting Plaintiff to excessive force.

40. Plaintiff asserts that the aforementioned unlawful acts committed by defendants are representative of a pervasive policy, custom or pattern and practice within the City of New York and the NYPD in particular.

41. Plaintiff assert that Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, illegally approached, stopped, searched, and then falsely arrested him, due solely to their racially discriminatory prejudices against African American or Hispanic males, their intent to use the instant arrest as leverage against Plaintiff , so that he would provide defendants with information regarding defendants' true and only suspects, or other unrelated crimes or criminal suspects, their desires to fulfill an unconstitutional arrest quota and to benefit from increased overtime compensation.

42. Plaintiff further assert that Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, acted in such an unlawfully reprehensible manner, due to their unsubstantiated and unreasonable presumptions that Plaintiff would be able provide said defendants with information pertaining to unrelated criminal activity or suspects, solely because of his status as African American or Hispanic male.

43. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, arrested and maliciously prosecuted Plaintiff , because of their racially discriminatory beliefs which compelled defendants to equate to Plaintiff 's race, ethnicity or national origin to criminal guilt or criminal knowledge.

44. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, perpetrated multiple overt acts in furtherance of their obviously discriminatory inclinations and biases, namely the stop, search, assault, battery, seizure, arrest, and malicious prosecution of Plaintiff, despite possessing no evidence, credible or otherwise, to justify such conduct.

45. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, unlawfully stopped, questioned, searched, seized, arrested, and maliciously prosecuted Plaintiff, due solely to

defendants' perception or consideration of Plaintiff's race, ethnicity, national origin, sex, gender or age.

46. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, subjected Plaintiff to disparate treatment compared to other individuals similarly situated, because defendants did not stop, accuse, search, seize, arrest or cause criminal prosecutions to be initiated against any accused nonminority persons, who were engaged in activity identical or substantially similar to the kind that resulted in the illegal search, seizure, detention, and prosecution of Plaintiff, namely minority persons merely grocery shopping in the vicinity of the above-referenced location at the above-referenced time, while in obedience of all local, state and federal laws.

47. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, unlawfully stopped, questioned, searched, seized, arrested, and maliciously prosecuted Plaintiff, because of their improper and pernicious desires to prevent Plaintiff from exerting his First Amendment right to engage in protected speech and activities, such as Plaintiff's right to refuse to yield to defendants' unreasonably coercive demands to utter false confessions or assist defendants in the fabrication of evidence against defendants' true suspects or other persons of interest.

48. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, possessed no valid reason to approach, stop, question, search or arrest Plaintiff, which gives rise to the strong inference that such conduct resulted from defendants' unjust motivations or proclivities, including defendants' invidious and biased based discriminatory predilections against African American or Hispanic males, such as Plaintiff, defendants' desire to retaliate, punish or otherwise penalize Plaintiff for his refusal to submit to the will of defendants by answering questions to the satisfaction of defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10.

49. Defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, engaged in a conspiracy to falsely arrest and maliciously prosecute Plaintiff by personally conferring with each other, regarding the fabrication of the aforementioned nonexistent evidence, the suppression of exculpatory evidence, as well the manner and means by which said fabrications would be forwarded to prosecutors.

50. Plaintiff asserts that the defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, who violated his civil rights, are part of a larger pattern and practice of similar misconduct, which is so widespread, pervasive and consistent throughout the NYPD and the City of New York that the commission of such constitutionally violative behavior has become tantamount to an official policy or custom within the NYPD and City of New York or, at the very least, conclusive evidence that the City and the NYPD have either tacitly approved of such egregious wrongdoings or that they have become deliberately indifferent to the civil rights of those who may come into contact with their police officers, including the individually named defendants herein.

51. The individually named defendants herein, as well as other officers serving in the employ of the NYPD and City of New York, have blatantly, shamelessly, consistently and repeatedly engaged in conduct violative of the civil rights guaranteed and protected by Constitution of the United States, in addition to the laws and constitution of the State of New York, all without incurring any ramifications for such misconduct and, ostensibly, with the full and complete blessing of the NYPD, the City of New York and their respective policymakers and supervisors.

52. *The New York Times*, as well as numerous other reputable journalistic enterprises, have reported on the widespread corruption within the NYPD and City of New York, particularly the incredibly disconcerting proclivity of many NYPD officers to lie about subject matters that are

materially relevant to criminal prosecutions, including the complete fabrication of arrest evidence and witnesses. Also detailed, is the NYPD's obstinate refusal to effectuate corrective or preventive measures to combat the inevitable recurrence of such misdeeds, and perhaps most troubling, the NYPD's alarming tendency to, instead, reward and promote these officers, including those who were inculcated via incontrovertible evidence, such as video evidence.

53. The constitutionally repugnant behavior that persists within the ranks of the NYPD results from the NYPD's own policies, rules and procedures, namely the NYPD's incredibly flawed and illegal use of arrest quotas. Despite its illegality, such policies remain systemic throughout the NYPD and its individual commands. The NYPD, however, was not content in compelling its officers to effect as many arrests as possible, regardless of the presence of any legal right to do, it promulgated various subsets of quotas, which are predicated on race, color or ethnicity. Additionally, the NYPD, its supervisors or policymakers would assign varying point values to arrests, which were, again, impermissibly based upon the arrestee's race, color or ethnicity. Unsurprisingly, officers would be better rewarded for minority arrests or summonses. This egregious conduct has reported by numerous respected media outlets and publications and has even formed the basis for federal lawsuits against the City and the NYPD, which were commenced by its own employee officers.

54. On June 17, 2020, the *New York Daily News* published an article, by Graham Rayman, entitled "Brooklyn Cop Claims he was Punished for not Meeting Arrest Quotas, Refusing to Take Responsibility for Controversial Arrest in which he Wasn't Involved," describing allegations from an NYPD Police Officer, Terrence Dickerson, that he was retaliated against by the NYPD for refusing to adhere to mandatory racially based arrest quotas and for his refusal to accept

responsibility for a controversial and publicized arrest via the excessive force, despite the fact that he was not even at the scene.

55. On March 18, 2018, *The New York Times* published an explosive article, entitled “Promotions, Not Punishments for Officers Accused of Lying,” written by Joseph Goldstein. Mr. Goldstein shines a light on the multitude of flaws within the CCRB and the NYPD, highlighting the fact that the substantiation of a claim against an officer will invariably rely on the presence of incontrovertible proof against the officer. Due to the rarity availability of this type of evidence, an alarmingly small percentage of officer misconduct claims are substantiated. The CCRB is further handicapped by a terribly designed system that requires evidence of a virtually indisputable nature to substantiate any claim against an officer. The article also details the NYPD’s persistent reluctance to investigate or discipline officers who lie and even posits that this reluctance is a significant cause of the lying pandemic within the NYPD. The article references various officers and detectives who were the subject of credible accusations relating to the officers’ intentionally false statements, with some allegations coming from federal and state judges.

56. On September 12, 2019, *The New York Times* published another article by Joseph Goldstein, entitled “Officers Said They Smelled Pot. The Judge Called Them Liars.” Unsurprisingly, this article dealt with the unusually high frequency of officers using the odor of marijuana to excuse a search that conspicuously does not result in the recovery of any marijuana. It should not require an article in *The New York Times* to call attention to such patently disingenuous tactics, but has become necessary for a variety of reasons, including the NYPD’s failure to correct such behavior, the willingness of prosecutors and judges to credit the lying officers and the increasing rate of occurrence.

57. On April 24, 2019, *The New York Times* published an article, entitled “Detective’s Lies Sent Three People to Prison, Prosecutors Charge,” by Sean Piccolo, detailing the lies of NYPD Second Grade Detective Joseph Franco and how those lies resulted in the imprisonment of at least three innocent people. The article described how Det. Franco lied about observing drug transactions on at least three separate occasions, lies that were only uncovered through contradictory video evidence. Det. Franco’s lies resulted in the innocent individuals each being sentenced to prison terms in excess of one-year.

58. Other articles include: (i) “Testilying’ by Police: A Stubborn Problem.,” by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, March 18, 2018; (ii) “New York Detective Charged with Faking Lineup Results,” by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, February 17, 2018; (iii) “He Excelled as a Detective, Until Prosecutors Stopped Believing Him,” by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, October 17, 2017; (iv) “Review Board Notes Rise in New York Police Officers’ False Statement,” by J. David Goodman, *The New York Times*, May 14, 2015; (v) “In Brooklyn Gun Cases, Suspicion Turns to the Police,” by Stephanie Clifford, *The New York Times*, December 11, 2014; (vi) “Detective is Found Guilty of Planting Drugs,” by Tim Stelloh, *The New York Times*, November 1, 2011; and (vii) “The Drugs? They Came from the Police,” by Jim Dwyer, *The New York Times*, October 13, 2011.

59. The NYPD has a longstanding and ignominious record of failing to discipline its officers, or even entertaining allegations of wrongdoing against them. On June 26, 2019, *The New York Times* published an article, entitled “2,495 Reports of Police Bias. Not One Was Deemed Valid by the N.Y.P.D.” This article reported that within the last five (5) years, almost 2,500 separate individuals have filed formal complaints with the NYPD alleging that an officer acted with bias toward them, with not a single one being substantiated by the NYPD. Such a finding is plainly

incredible and obviously the result of deliberately poor or nonexistent investigatory protocols. The report further impugned the NYPD's commitment to combat the prejudices and the biases exhibited by many of its officers.

60. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policymakers, officials or supervisors have imposed, tacitly approved or acquiesced to policies, customs, or patterns and practices within the NYPD that resulted in the arrest and criminal prosecution of Plaintiff without probable cause.

61. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policymakers or supervisors have failed to provide adequate training regarding the identification of probable cause, reasonable suspicion or the appropriate amount of force to be used.

62. Defendants' actions with respect to the underlying arrest of Plaintiff, which occurred without even the semblance of probable cause, were so blatantly violative of Plaintiff's civil rights that the tacit approval of identical or similar acts by the policymakers or supervisors of the NYPD and the City of New York, as well as their deliberate indifference towards the rights of any individuals who may come into contact with Defendants, should be inferred, because such flagrant deprivations of constitutionally protected rights could not and would not occur without the tacit approval or deliberate indifference regarding the commission of such violations by the policymakers or supervisors of the NYPD and City of New York.

63. Upon information and belief, further details and facts, relating to the unlawful policies, customs or patterns and practices of the NYPD, City of New York and their respective policymakers, supervisors, police officers or employees, will become known after the completion of discovery, as such information is presently within the exclusive possession of Defendants, the NYPD and City of New York.

64. Upon information and belief, the personnel files, records and disciplinary histories of the officer Defendants will reveal a history of Constitutional violations indicative of defendant City's knowledge that the individual officer Defendants were unfit for employment as NYPD officers, or for employment in general, and that the probability of the individually named Defendants committing similar violations in the future was extremely high.

65. Upon information and belief, said personnel files, records and disciplinary histories will conclusively show that the City and the NYPD were fully aware of Defendants' past constitutional violations, the unacceptably high probability for the recurrence of similar transgressions, the unreasonably dangerous situations that were likely to result from their hiring or retention, as well as their unsuitability for employment as law enforcement officers, or for employment in general, and that the NYPD and City of New York failed to engage in any preventive or corrective action intended to diminish the likelihood of recurrence for such violations, which is tantamount to the City's tacit approval of such misconduct or the City's deliberate indifference towards the civil rights of those who may interact with its employees, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10.

66. Upon information and belief, the NYPD and City of New York and have failed, or outright refused, to correct the individually named Defendants' predilections to engage in unconstitutional behavior or attempt to prevent the recurrence of such misconduct.

67. The aforementioned acts of defendants, including AKTARUZZAMAN and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10, directly or proximately resulted in the deprivation or violation of Plaintiff's civil rights, as enumerated and set forth by the First, Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States, the constitution of the State of New York and the laws of the City and State of New York.

68. As direct or proximate results of said acts, Plaintiff was caused to suffer the loss of his liberty, irreparable reputational harm, the loss of earnings and potential earnings, substantial and permanent physical and psychological injuries, as well as severe and permanent emotional distress, including fear, embarrassment, humiliation, traumatization, frustration, extreme inconvenience and anxiety.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Protected Speech or Activity Retaliation Claim Under
New York State Law

69. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

70. Plaintiff engaged in speech and activities that were protected by § 8, Article I, of the constitution of the State of New York.

71. Defendants committed impermissible or unlawful actions against Plaintiff that were motivated or substantially caused by Plaintiff's constitutionally protected speech or activities.

72. Defendants' retaliatory actions against Plaintiff resulted in deprivations to his liberty and the initiation of criminal charges against him in the absence of probable cause.

73. Defendants' retaliatory actions adversely affected Plaintiff's protected speech or activities by physically or procedurally preventing him from further pursuing said protected speech or activities or by chilling his desire to further participate or engage in such protected speech or activities.

74. Accordingly, Plaintiff's rights to engage in protected speech and activities, guaranteed and protected by § 8, Article I, of the constitution of the State of New York, were violated by defendants.

75. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoings, under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

76. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

First Amendment Retaliation Claim Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

77. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

78. Plaintiff engaged in speech and activities that were protected by the First Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

79. Defendants committed impermissible or unlawful actions against Plaintiff that were motivated or substantially caused by Plaintiff's Constitutionally protected speech or activities, under the First Amendment.

80. Defendants' retaliatory actions against Plaintiff resulted in deprivations to his liberty and the initiation of criminal charges against him in the absence of probable cause.

81. Defendants' retaliatory actions adversely affected Plaintiff's protected speech or activities by physically or procedurally preventing him from further pursuing said protected speech or activities, or by chilling his desires to further participate or engage in such protected speech or activities.

82. Accordingly, Plaintiff's right to engage in protected speech and activities, as guaranteed and protected by the First Amendment to the Constitution of the United States, was violated by defendants.

83. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Search & Seizure Under
New York State Law

84. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

85. Defendants subjected Plaintiff's person and their property to unreasonable searches and seizures without a valid warrant and without reasonable suspicion or probable cause do so.

86. Plaintiff was conscious and fully aware of the unreasonable searches and seizures to his persons and property.

87. Plaintiff did not consent to the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person or property.

88. The unreasonable searches and seizures to Plaintiff's person and property were not otherwise privileged.

89. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's right to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, pursuant to § 12, Article I, of the constitution of the State of New York and § 8, Article II, of the New York Civil Rights Law.

90. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoings under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

91. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION
Unlawful Search & Seizure Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

92. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

93. Defendants subjected Plaintiff's person and his property to unreasonable searches and seizures without a valid warrant and without reasonable suspicion or probable cause do so.

94. Plaintiff were conscious and fully aware of the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person and property.

95. Plaintiff did not consent to the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person or property.

96. The unreasonable searches and seizures to Plaintiff's person and property were not otherwise privileged.

97. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, pursuant to the Fourth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

98. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest & False Imprisonment Under
New York State Law

99. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

100. Defendants subjected Plaintiff to false arrest, false imprisonment, and the deprivation of liberty without probable cause.

101. Plaintiff was conscious of his confinement.

102. Plaintiff did not consent to his confinement.

103. The arrest and imprisonment of Plaintiff were not otherwise privileged.

104. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

105. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest & False Imprisonment Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

106. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

107. The Defendants violated the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States by wrongfully and illegally arresting, detaining and imprisoning Plaintiff.

108. The wrongful, unjustifiable, and unlawful apprehension, arrest, detention, and imprisonment of Plaintiff were carried out without a valid warrant, without Plaintiff's consent, and without probable cause or reasonable suspicion.

109. At all relevant times, Defendants acted forcibly in apprehending, arresting, and imprisoning Plaintiff.

110. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Assault & Battery Under
New York State Law

111. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

112. Defendants caused Plaintiff fear for their physical well-being and safety and placed him in apprehension of immediate harmful or offensive touching.

113. Defendants engaged in and subjected Plaintiff to immediate harmful or offensive touching and battered him without his consent or other legal justification therefor.

114. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

115. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages alleged herein.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Excessive Force Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

116. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

117. The Defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States, because they used unreasonable force without the consent of Plaintiff.

118. Defendants engaged in and subjected Plaintiff to immediate harmful or offensive touching and battered him without consent.

119. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages alleged herein.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Prosecution Under
New York State Law

120. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

121. Defendants initiated the criminal prosecution against Plaintiff.

122. Defendants lacked probable cause to believe Plaintiff was guilty or that the criminal prosecution would succeed.

123. Defendants acted with malice, which may be inferred in the absence of probable cause.

124. The prosecution was terminated in favor of Plaintiff, when all adverse charges were unconditionally and outright dismissed on the merits, due to the lack of probable cause to believe that Plaintiff had committed a crime or that the prosecution would succeed.

125. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

126. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages alleged herein.

TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Prosecution Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

127. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

128. Defendants initiated the criminal prosecution against Plaintiff.

129. Defendants lacked probable cause to believe Plaintiff was guilty or that the criminal prosecution would succeed.

130. Defendants acted with malice, which may be inferred in the absence of probable cause.

131. The prosecution was terminated in favor of Plaintiff, when all adverse charges were unconditionally dismissed on the merits, due to the lack of probable cause to believe that Plaintiff had committed any crime or that the prosecution would succeed.

132. Accordingly, Defendants violated Plaintiff's rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

133. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

ELEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Abuse of Process Under
New York State Law

134. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

135. Defendants arrested, detained and caused a criminal prosecution to be initiated against Plaintiff to compel the compliance or forbearance of some act.

136. Defendants had no excuse or justification to forcibly detain or initiate a criminal prosecution against Plaintiff, especially in the absence of any cognizable probable cause.

137. Defendants intended to inflict substantial harm upon Plaintiff.

138. Defendants acted to achieve a collateral purpose, beyond or in addition to the criminal prosecution initiated and thereafter maintained against Plaintiff.

139. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

140. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

TWELFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Abuse of Process Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

141. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

142. Defendants arrested, detained and caused criminal prosecution to be initiated against Plaintiff to compel the compliance or forbearance of some act.

143. Defendants had no excuse or justification to forcibly detain or initiate criminal prosecution against Plaintiff, especially in the absence of any cognizable probable cause.

144. Defendants intended to inflict substantial harm upon Plaintiff.

145. Defendants acted to achieve a collateral purpose, beyond or in addition to the criminal prosecution initiated and thereafter maintained against Plaintiff.

146. Defendants' actions therefore resulted in deprivations to Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

147. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

THIRTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Denial of Right to Due Process Under
New York State Law

148. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

149. Defendants fabricated false evidence to be used against Plaintiff that was likely to influence a jury's decision.

150. Defendants forwarded said fabrications and false information to prosecutors.

151. Defendants' actions resulted in deprivations to the liberty and freedom of movement of Plaintiff after legal process had attached following his arraignment in criminal court.

152. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's right to Due Process, pursuant to §§ 1, 2, and 6, of Article I, of the constitution of the State of New York, and § 12, Article II, of the New York Civil Rights Law.

153. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

154. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

FOURTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Denial of Rights to Fair Trial & Due Process Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

155. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

156. Defendants engaged in the fabrication of evidence likely to influence a jury's decision.

157. Defendants forwarded said fabrications and false information to prosecutors.

158. Defendants' actions resulted in deprivations to the liberty and freedom of movement of Plaintiff after legal process had attached following his arraignment in criminal court.

159. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to Constitution of the United States.

160. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

FIFTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Victims of Violent Crime Protection Act Under
New York City Law

161. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

162. Defendants' acts or series of acts constituted the commission of a misdemeanor or felony against Plaintiff, as defined in state or federal law, which presented a serious risk of physical injury to Plaintiff, regardless of whether said acts actually resulted in criminal charges, prosecutions or convictions.

163. Accordingly, defendants committed crimes of violence against Plaintiff and violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to § 10-403 of the Administrative Code of the City of New York.

164. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

165. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

SIXTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTIONBiased Based Profiling Under
New York City Law

166. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

167. Defendants impermissibly relied upon the actual or perceived race, color, national origin, ancestry, citizenship status, gender, religion, religious practice, age, disability or sexual orientation of Plaintiff as the determinative factor in initiating law enforcement actions against Plaintiff, rather than Plaintiff's behavior or other information or circumstances that would link Plaintiff to suspected unlawful activity.

168. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to § 14-151 of the Administrative Code of the City of New York.

169. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

170. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

SEVENTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTIONDeprivation of Rights & Denial of Equal Protection of the Laws Under
New York State Law

171. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

172. Plaintiff, as a Black or African American male, belongs to a racial minority and a protected class.

173. Defendants discriminated against Plaintiff on the basis of race, color, national origin, ancestry, gender, religion, religious practice, age, disability or sexual orientation.

174. Defendants also engaged in the selective treatment of Plaintiff, in comparison to others similarly situated.

175. Defendants' discriminatory treatment of Plaintiff was based on impermissible considerations,

such as race, color, ethnicity, an intent to inhibit or punish Plaintiff for the exertion of their Constitutional rights, or a malicious or bad faith intent to injure Plaintiff.

176. Defendants applied facially neutral laws against Plaintiff in a discriminatory manner.

177. Defendants, motivated by racial animus, applied facially neutral statutes with adverse effects against Plaintiff.

178. Defendants did not possess a rational basis, excuse or justification for applying any laws or statutes against Plaintiff.

179. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to § 11, Article I, of the constitution of the State of New York, § 79-N, Article VII, of the New York Civil Rights Law and § 296, ¶ 13, of the New York Executive Law.

180. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

181. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

EIGHTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Deprivation of Rights & Denial of Equal Protection of the Laws Under
42 U.S.C. §§ 1981 & 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

182. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

183. Plaintiff, as a Black or African American male, belongs to a racial minority and a protected class.

184. Defendants discriminated against Plaintiff on the basis of race, color, ethnicity or national origin.

185. Defendants engaged in the selective treatment of Plaintiff in comparison to others similarly situated.

186. Defendants' selective treatment of Plaintiff was based on impermissible considerations, such

as race, color, ethnicity, an intent to inhibit or punish Plaintiff for the exertion of their Constitutional rights, or malicious or bad faith intent to injure Plaintiff.

187. Defendants applied facially neutral laws against Plaintiff in a discriminatory manner.

188. Defendants, motivated by racial animus, applied facially neutral penal statutes with adverse effects against Plaintiff.

189. Defendants did not possess a rational basis, excuse or justification for applying any laws or statutes against Plaintiff.

190. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, under the Equal Protection Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

191. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

192. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

NINETEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Conspiracy to Interfere with Civil Rights & Failure to Prevent the Conspiracy Under
42 U.S.C. §§ 1983, 1985 & 1986 *Against* Individual Defendants

193. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

194. Defendants engaged in a conspiracy against Plaintiff to deprive him of his rights to engage in protected speech or activities, to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, to be afforded a fair trial, and to not be deprived of their liberty or property without Due Process of Law, in addition to Plaintiff's Constitutionally guaranteed privileges and immunities under the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

195. Defendants committed overt acts in furtherance of their conspiracy against Plaintiff.

196. As a result, Plaintiff sustained injuries to his person, was deprived of his liberty, rights or privileges as a citizen of the United States.

197. Defendants' conspiracy was motivated by a desire to deprive Plaintiff of his civil rights or because of some racial or otherwise class-based, invidious or discriminatory animus.

198. The Defendants that did not engage or participate in the conspiracy to interfere with Plaintiff's civil rights, had knowledge that acts in furtherance of the conspiracy were about to be committed or in the process of being committed, possessed the power to prevent or aid in the prevention of the conspiratorial objective, and neglected to do so.

199. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to the First, Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

200. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

201. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

TWENTIETH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene Under
New York State Law

202. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

203. Those Defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct, observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct, and failed to intervene.

204. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

205. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

TWENTY-FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Individual Defendants

206. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

207. Those Defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct, and failed to intervene.

208. Accordingly, the Defendants who failed to intervene violated the First, Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

209. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

TWENTY-SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Hiring, Training, Retention & Supervision Under
New York State Law

210. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

211. Defendant City owed a duty of care to Plaintiff to adequately hire, train, retain and supervise its employee defendants.

212. Defendant City breached those duties of care.

213. Defendant City placed the individually named defendants herein in a position where they could inflict foreseeable harm.

214. Defendant City knew or should have known of the individual named defendants' propensities for violating the individual civil rights of those they interacted with prior to the injuries incurred by Plaintiff.

215. Defendant City failed to take reasonable measures in hiring, training, retaining or supervising the individually named defendants, which would have prevented or mitigated the aforesaid injuries suffered by Plaintiff.

216. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

TWENTY-THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Municipal “*Monell*” Liability Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 *Against* Defendant City

217. The above paragraphs are hereby incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

218. Defendant City maintained a policy or custom that caused Plaintiff to be deprived of their civil rights, tacitly approved of such violative conduct or was deliberately indifferent toward the potential exposure of those who may interact with the individually named defendants to such Constitutionally repugnant behavior, such as Plaintiff.

219. Defendant City’s employee police officers have engaged in an illegal pattern and practice of misconduct, so consistent and widespread that it constitutes a custom or usage, of which a supervisor or policymaker must have been aware of.

220. Defendant City and its policymakers failed to provide adequate training or supervision to their subordinates to such an extent that is tantamount to their deliberate indifference toward the rights of those who may come into contact with the defendant City’s employee police officers, including the individually named police officers herein.

221. Defendant City’s employee police officers engaged in such egregious and flagrant violations of Plaintiff’s Constitutional rights that the need for enhanced training or supervision is obvious and equates to the exhibition of deliberate indifference by defendant City and its officials, policymakers or supervisors toward the rights of individuals, who may come into contact with defendant City’s employee police officers, including the individually named defendants herein.

222. Defendant City’s repeated willful refusals or unexcused failures to install or apply corrective or preventive measures constitutes its tacit approval or deliberate indifference with respect to violations of the civil or Constitutional rights of those who may come into contact with NYPD officers, including the individually named defendants herein.

223. Defendant City's conduct resulted in violations of Plaintiff's civil rights, under the First, Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

224. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained damages.

JURY DEMAND

Plaintiff hereby demands a trial by jury.

Dated: Bayside, New York
April 17, 2023

SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP

By: 

Sameer Nath, Esq.
Attorneys for Plaintiff
42-40 Bell Boulevard – Suite 405
Bayside, New York 11361
(718) 281-0400

ATTORNEY VERIFICATION

I, Sameer Nath, an attorney admitted to practice in the courts of New York State, state that I am an associate with the firm of **SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP**, the attorneys of record for Plaintiff in the within action; I have read the foregoing and know the contents thereof; the same is true to my own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged on information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. The reason this verification is made by me and not by Plaintiff, is because Plaintiff resides outside the county where deponent maintains his office. I affirm that the foregoing statements are true, under the penalties of perjury.

Dated: Bayside, New York
April 17, 2023



SAMEER NATH, ESQ.